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Toll from Iran port explosion rises to 28 dead, 1,000 injured

BLAST FELT AND HEARD ABOUT 50KM AWAY; FIRES STILL RAGING ON

TEHRAN

The death toll from Saturday's massive explosion at Iran's largest commercial port has risen to 28, Red Crescent chief Pirhossein Koolivand said yesterday, updating earlier figures reported by state media.

"Unfortunately, 28 people have so far died," Koolivand said in a video published on the Iranian government's official website, adding that some of the more than 1,000 injured in the Shahid Rajaei Port blast on Saturday had been transferred to the capital Tehran for treatment.

Iran's defence ministry said there was no military cargo at the site. The *New York Times* quoted a person with ties to Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, speaking on condition of anonymity to discuss security matters, as saying that what exploded was sodium perchlorate — a major ingredient in solid fuel for missiles.

Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian yesterday travelled to the site. Fires were still blazing yesterday, according to state media. The Russian embassy in Tehran said yesterday that Moscow was sending rescue teams to Iran to help fight the blaze.

Busy port

The blast occurred on Saturday at Shahid Rajaei Port in southern Iran, near the Strait of Hormuz, through which a fifth of world oil output passes.

The port's customs office said in a statement carried by state



Firefighters and rescuers work yesterday at the scene of an explosion that took place at the Shahid Rajaei Port dock, southwest of Bandar Abbas in the Iranian province of Hormozgan.

With choking smoke and air pollution spreading throughout the area, all schools and offices in Bandar Abbas, the nearby capital of Hormozgan province, were ordered closed yesterday.

television that the explosion probably resulted from a fire that broke out at the hazardous and chemical materials storage depot. A regional emergency official said several containers had exploded.

Thick black smoke was still visible in live footage from the scene. "The fire is under control but still not out," a state TV correspondent reported from the

site around 20 hours after the blast. The explosion was so powerful that it was felt and heard about 50 kilometres (30 miles) away, Fars news agency reported. Images from news agency IRNA on Saturday showed rescuers and survivors walking along a wide boulevard carpeted with debris after the blast at Shahid Rajaei, more than 1,000 kilometres south of Tehran.

"The shockwave was so strong that most of the port buildings were severely damaged," Tasnim news agency reported.

The authorities have closed off the roads leading to the site of the explosion, and footage from the area has been limited to Iranian media outlets.

With choking smoke and air pollution spreading throughout the area, all schools and offices in Bandar Abbas, the nearby capital of Hormozgan province, were ordered closed yesterday to allow authorities to focus on the emergency effort, state TV said.

— AFP
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UAE leads the Arab world in Swiss watch imports in 2025

Saudi Arabia ranks second, followed by Qatar, Kuwait and Bahrain

DUBAI

Gulf News Report

The UAE has topped Arab countries as the largest importer of Swiss watches in 2025, according to new data from the Federation of the Swiss Watch Industry.

During the first quarter of the year, the UAE imported approximately \$335 million worth of Swiss watches, placing it well ahead of other Arab markets. The figure represents more than half of the total value of Swiss watch imports into the Arab world.

Saudi Arabia ranked second with imports valued at around \$92 million, followed closely by Qatar with \$87 million. Kuwait and Bahrain rounded out the top five, recording imports of approximately \$46 million and \$29 million, respectively.

All five top importing countries are GCC members. This highlights the continued



dominance of GCC countries in the region's luxury watch market.

Swiss watches have long been seen as a symbol of status and refinement in the Gulf, where luxury consumption is a major driver of the regional economy.

Higher demand

According to Bloomberg, Independent Swiss watchmaker MB&F's founder Maximilian Büsler used to struggle to sell even two ultra-luxury timepieces in the Middle East a few years ago. Last year, his firm sold 46 in the region, some worth as much as \$240,000.

At Dubai's biggest mall, business has been so brisk that MB&F had only one watch left on display this January, requiring more to be shipped in from Geneva. People were coming to the store and asking, "Can I try something on?," Büsler said, and the answer often was: "No, sorry. We have nothing."

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